Peace for progress

Economic objectives can be met only in a stable security environment

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh's address at the SCO Council of Heads of Government meeting in Tajikistan, on Tuesday marks another significant occasion since Operation Sindoor (2025) when India has used the multilateral forum to raise the issue of terrorism, including cross-border terrorism from Pakistan. He said that regional cooperation cannot be meaningful if countries approached terrorism selectively. Pakistan's Deputy Prime Minister Ishaq Dar's presence added significance to the remarks, underscoring New Delhi's diplomatic challenge within an organisation whose members have divergent strategic interests and security priorities. India has consistently argued that terrorism cannot be divorced from the broader agenda of regional peace, economic integration and development. By calling on SCO member-states to dismantle the ecosystem of terrorism, he reiterated that the threat must be addressed at its source rather than treated as an isolated security challenge. The intervention follows India's refusal to endorse the joint statement at the 2025 SCO Defence Ministers' meet in Qingdao, China. New Delhi had objected to a draft that failed to reflect its concerns over cross-border and Pakistan-sponsored terrorism, including the Pahalgam attack (2025), while referring to militant activities in Balochistan. India maintained that such an approach would undermine the organisation's credibility by overlooking the threat it had brought before its members.

The SCO has the potential to advance regional stability, trade and connectivity instead of becoming another source of strategic friction. Yet, its effectiveness will remain limited if political disagreements prevent members from developing a common approach to security threats. India's position is not that cooperation on trade, culture, connectivity and development must be suspended until every security dispute is resolved. Rather, these objectives cannot be met independently of a stable security environment. Economic corridors require predictable borders, investors need confidence in the rule of law, and transport networks must be violence- and disruption-free. Connectivity projects such as the International North-South Transport Corridor and the development of Chabahar Port offer Central Asia connectivity with wider markets. Their long-term value, however, depends on respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, alongside conditions that allow goods, capital and people to move freely. The SCO's challenge is to translate its stated commitment to combating terrorism into practical cooperation through intelligence-sharing, action against terror financing, disruption of recruitment networks and the denial of safe havens to terrorist groups. While retaining its principle against terrorism, India should lead efforts to achieve more regional cooperation in tackling it.

Bitter and sweet

The FSSAI must expand restrictions to cover all added sugars in infant foods

The Food Safety and Standards Regulations 2020 currently allow manufacturers to add sucrose and fructose, provided their combined total does not exceed 20% of the carbohydrates in a product intended for infants aged 0-6 months. In a draft proposal, the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has pitched to eliminate this allowance – in line with WHO's recommendation to have infants breastfeed exclusively for the first six months, followed by nutritionally adequate complementary foods avoiding added sugars until 24 months. While corporations have defended sugary formulations as abiding by the Codex Alimentarius, public health experts have repeatedly described their decision to sell infant foods with added sugar as nutritional dumping. Adding sugar has often been a commercial strategy, as it serves as a cheap bulking agent, improves palatability and encourages repeat purchases. WHO's nutrient and promotion profile model for baby foods in 2022 also identified sweet purées and products in which fruits released sugars during processing as concerns. While the FSSAI's draft proposal is a step in the right direction, stopping here would allow manufacturers to replace sucrose with another sweetening ingredient. It should assess the ingredients that manufacturers add and the nutritional profile of the finished food, thus completing the loop, with the Infant Milk Substitutes, Feeding Bottles, and Infant Foods Act 1992 rightly restricting aggressively the marketing of infant foods for children up to two years old.

Research has found that children who regularly received sweetened water during infancy subsequently preferred sweeter liquids, while exposure to different infant formula flavours influenced their dietary preferences years later, including for foods tasting neutral or bitter. Across both personal and public health dimensions, then, infants need to encounter diverse flavours. Since the 2024 dietary guidelines of the ICMR-National Institute of Nutrition say that children under two should avoid added sugars, the FSSAI's draft proposal limiting itself to six months seems like a concession to manufacturers. This should be avoided since India's regulatory response to ultra-processed foods is expanding after years of sluggishness. India is currently mulling restrictions on added sugar in foods for the youngest infants, on unhealthy foods around schools, and on front-of-pack labelling for packaged foods. If the FSSAI does not expand its proposed restriction to cover all added sugars and extend it across the first 24 months, and pair it with mandatory, interpretative front-of-pack labelling for all foods, its regulatory progress will remain incomplete.

The struggle to preserve a fair international law



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The news that South African jurist Navi Pillay is the recipient of the 2026 Nobel Peace Prize could not have come at a better time for those agonisingly disconcerted by global apathy towards international law. At a time when international law is being battered by powerful, authoritarian men, drunk on power and willing to go to any lengths to pursue their imperialistic designs, the Nobel Committee has unequivocally signalled that international law matters. The real question, however, is what kind of international law matters.

Multiple narratives shape international law. One key narrative, as mentioned, is that vital tenets of international law, such as prohibiting the use of force in international relations, have been completely shredded, with multiple wars raging. Likewise, with rising authoritarianism, there has been a precipitous waning in compliance with international human rights law and an increase in the commission of war crimes and crimes against humanity.

While the normative decline of international law has been going on for quite some time, the fall has been precipitous in recent years, accompanied by utter disdain for universally accepted international norms. This scornful attitude towards international law became evident when (then) U.S. President Joe Biden leaned heavily towards using the ambiguous term "rules-based order" instead of "international law", signalling a movement towards an era of norm-light global governance. U.S. President Donald Trump took this several notches up when he said that he did not need international law because he was guided by his own morality.

Authoritarian international law

This brings us to what Tom Ginsburg calls authoritarian international law – an attempt to create a new normative order. Thus, while authoritarian leaders attacking the fundamental tenets of international law might give the impression that they are hollowing it out, the more nuanced picture is that authoritarians are retooling international law to pursue their objectives. As Ginsburg, Shirley Scott and others argue, the liberal international law order that emerged after the Second World War and which intensified after the end of the Cold War was a product of what democratic states did on the international plane.

Although the liberal international law order's democratic credentials can always be questioned, civil, political and human rights were institutionalised and made part of its operating system. Countries created international organisations (IOs) to which they delegated significant powers, accompanied by high judicialisation – the creation of international courts and tribunals to settle disputes.

A scant respect for rights

With the rise of authoritarianism, including in liberal democracies, the fundamental nature of the liberal international legal order is being altered or, as Anne Applebaum argues, its operating system is changing. Authoritarian states view international law as a tool for coordinating regime survival. Respect for civil, political and human rights, and holding executive power accountable for war crimes and crimes against humanity, has little place in the authoritarian international legal order. Innovative uses of the age-old concept of sovereignty are another key feature. While developing countries often invoke sovereignty to shape international legal norms to serve their aspirations, today, sovereignty seems to be the cloak aimed at shielding authoritarian regimes' excesses from international scrutiny. Israel's systematic rejection of reports by UN human rights bodies that chide it for human rights violations, on the grounds that they interfere in its sovereign affairs, is a case in point.

> Authoritarian leaders are undermining legal norms and reshaping international institutions to serve their interests

Creating weak IOs with limited independent powers is another key feature of authoritarian international law. Once created, an IO takes on a life of its own, and member-states should not be able to control on a whim. This, however, does not suit authoritarian states, which want to retain maximum power while delegating as little as possible to IOs. The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation is a case in point. A preference for negotiation or quasi-judicial mechanisms to resolve disputes, rather than faith in third-party international adjudication, is also a pivotal attribute of authoritarian international law. The recent backlash against international courts, such as the International Criminal Court, is an example.

The need for a fightback

The kind of international law that Ms. Pillay represents is what most authoritarian regimes despise. The clearest example of this is Israel's condemnation of the Nobel prize, saying that the Nobel Committee has awarded the prize to the "greatest lie" of the 21st century. Israel was referring to Ms. Pillay's role as the Chair of the UN's Independent International Commission of Inquiry on the Occupied Palestinian Territory, which concluded that Israel has committed genocide in Gaza.

Rather than serving merely as a tool for extending a regime's influence and values beyond its borders, the kind of international law that Ms. Pillay represents has a thicker conception of the rule of law, laced with values of equality, fairness, accountability and making the individual a subject of international law. Authoritarian regimes cannot be expected to develop a fair international legal order premised on justice. Other actors, including courts, civil society and academia, must therefore mount international resistance to authoritarian regimes to pave the way for a liberal and fair international law.

The views expressed are personal